Secrecy mitigates these risks by allowing leaders to engage with IOs discreetly, shielding their participation from public scrutiny. This enables populists to reap the benefits of IO cooperation while maintaining their public image as critics of international institutions. For leaders who perform populism strategically, secrecy reduces the risk of their being penalized by voters for perceived hypocrisy, particularly when cooperation involves politically sensitive issues like economic austerity or structural reforms.

Even genuine populists, who harbor deep ideological distrust of IOs, may find secrecy appealing. While they face ideological costs from engaging with IOs, hidden cooperation minimizes the domestic fallout, increasing the likelihood that the benefits of engagement will outweigh the costs. Moreover, many IOs have robust confidentiality measures—such as classification schemes and professional penalties for leaks—that reassure leaders of the low risk of exposure. For instance, the IMF employs stringent archival practices to protect sensitive communications, making covert interactions viable even for leaders wary of leaks.

Interviews with IMF officials illustrate how secrecy facilitates engagement with skeptical leaders. A former IMF resident representative recounted the case of Namibia in the 2000s, where the left-leaning government publicly resisted the Fund's advice while privately acknowledging its merit. The official described a dual reality in which Namibian leaders were cooperative behind closed doors but performed opposition publicly to align with their domestic political narrative. This dynamic underscores the role of secrecy in enabling IOs to work constructively with populist governments while allowing leaders to maintain their political personas.[6]

From the perspective of IOs, secrecy is a pragmatic but imperfect solution. While it fosters cooperation and preserves organizational relevance, it also allows populists to scapegoat IOs publicly while reaping the rewards of private engagement. This duality erodes public confidence in IOs, as citizens often rely on elite cues to form opinions about IOs (Brutger and Clark 2022; Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023). By enabling populists to denounce IOs while benefiting from their support, secrecy can reinforce narratives of IO elitism and unaccountability.

Furthermore, secrecy does little to address the underlying grievances that drive populist resistance to IOs. Instead, it perpetuates the perception of IOs